careful, how can we possibly force an open and honest probe into such shocking atrocities? This was a question that we debated internally. While some agreed that the Yatra should not generate controversy or provoke retaliation, some expressed regret.

On one other issue as well there was some discontent among us. Rahul Gandhi shows great courage in naming and shaming the Modi–Adani nexus,[1] but why can't he also stop state Congress governments from awarding Adani multiple contracts? Those contracts adversely affect the Adivasi and Other Forest Dwellers.[2] So while Rahul is eager to join the Adivasi in their fight for their livelihood, dignity and right over the forest, why won't he also attack the root cause (especially in states that the Congress had control over)? Rahul undoubtedly heard the Narmada and the Hasdeo forest issues sensitively. However, we were all thinking about this. Can this young leader, who genuinely felt their pain and understood their suffering, also concretely lay out an alternative path? And will he be able to take along all the leaders and workers of his party on the long journey ahead? This is *the* question that is in everyone's mind today.

Along with this fundamental question is another foundational one that cropped up when the youth who walked with Rahul sat down with me later. What next after the Yatra? It was evident that neither the Congress nor the youth had any tangible plans!

As someone who has been in the service of India's people for decades, I can safely say from experience that to be in public service, one has to devote one's life to the betterment of society and the people. To create lasting change, one has to shed all personal expectations of glory and reward. In that sense, I feel a path must be shown to India's youth, who came forward in the Yatra to serve the nation. The Yatra undoubtedly acted like a catalyst for the lakhs of farmers, farm labourers and villagers who marched or just cheered it on. Even those wearing saffron gamchhas (shawls) and adorning tilaks on their foreheads (some from the Shiv Sena but also some from the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh and the BJP; in fact, funnily, even though they joined enthusiastically, when we asked them to take photos with us, they promptly disappeared. They didn't want to be seen